Homebox 2.0

The complete manual: how it works, every page, every button, every setting and every function, from A to Z.

Product	Homebox for Windows: desktop app, browser extension, VS Code extension, app bridges and website
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Made by	Jethin Production
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Who this is for	Anyone using Homebox, from complete beginners (Parts 1 to 6) to the owner and developers maintaining it (Parts 7 to 12)

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PART 1

What Homebox is

Homebox lets an AI you chat with (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini and others) actually do work on your computer: create and edit files, and work live inside programs such as Blender, Maya, Photoshop, Excel, OBS and VS Code. You stay in control. You see every step, approve it, and can undo file changes.

1.1 The idea in one minute

Normally, when an AI writes code or a document for you, **you** do the boring part: copy it from the chat, paste it into a file or app, run it, copy any error back, and repeat. Homebox does that loop for you:

1. You type a task in the Homebox panel on an AI chat site, for example *"Make a simple website for my bakery"*.
2. The AI answers with small, clearly marked steps (called **homebox blocks**).
3. Homebox reads those steps and shows them to you. You click **Approve** (or Full access approves for you).
4. Homebox carries them out on your PC: writes the files, runs the step in Blender, and so on.
5. Homebox sends the result back into the chat automatically, and the AI continues with the next step.
6. When the AI is finished, it writes **DONE**. You open your AI folder or app and see the result.

1.2 The five pieces

Piece	What it is	Where you see it
Homebox app	The "engine". A Windows program that runs a small private server on your own PC (address `127.0.0.1`, port 7777). Only programs on your computer can talk to it. It holds your settings, the approval queue, the activity log and undo copies.	A window with a sidebar (Home, Approvals, Activity, ...) and an icon in the Windows tray.
Browser extension	Adds a round **Homebox** button and panel to AI chat sites. It sends your task to the AI, spots the AI's steps, passes them to the app, and puts the results back in the chat.	Chrome, Edge, Brave or Opera. The button at the bottom right of the chat site, and an icon in the toolbar.
App bridges	Small connectors that let Homebox work inside other programs (Maya, Blender, Photoshop, Excel, OBS...).	The **Apps** page in the Homebox app.
VS Code extension	Lets Homebox see what you're doing in VS Code (open files, errors) and open files it changed.	A "Homebox" item in VS Code's status bar.
Website	The public site with guides, download, FAQ and legal pages. Earns money through Google AdSense.	The `website` folder; published online.

1.3 What happens when you give a task

You type a task → Extension adds instructions and sends it to the AI → AI replies with homebox blocks → Extension sends the steps to the Homebox app → App checks permissions; asks you if needed → App does the step, keeps an undo copy, logs it → Results go back into the chat → AI continues… until DONE

The first time you start a task in a chat, the extension adds a **starter prompt** in front of your words. It tells the AI how to write homebox blocks, which functions it may use (only the ones you turned on), and the rules (stay in the folder, max ~5 actions per message, finish with DONE). Because of this, always type your task in the Homebox panel, not in the chat's own message box.

1.4 Words you will see

AI folder (sandbox)	The one folder the AI may see and change. Default: `C:\Users\<you>\Homebox Workspace`.
Allowed site	A website you let the AI use with "Let AI control this site" in the browser toolbar.
Approval	A step waiting for you to click Approve or Deny.
Full access	A switch that approves everything you turned on, automatically.
Pause	An emergency switch that instantly blocks all AI access.
Round	One back-and-forth: the AI writes steps, Homebox runs them and sends results.
Pairing	Connecting a browser to the app once, by confirming a matching code.
homebox block	A code block in the AI's reply, starting with ```` ```homebox ````, that holds a step.

A longer glossary is at the end (Part 14).

PART 2

Installing and first start

2.1 What you need

- Windows 10 or 11 (64-bit).
- Chrome, Edge, Brave or Opera (for the browser extension).
- An account with an AI service you choose, used under that service's terms (see Part 13).
- Optional: the programs you want the AI to work in (Blender, Maya, Photoshop, Excel, VS Code…).

2.2 Installing the app

1. Run `Homebox-Setup-2.0.0.exe`.
2. Read the licence agreement and click **I Agree**.
3. Choose where to install (the default is fine) and click **Install**.
4. Homebox opens and places a shortcut on your desktop and in the Start menu.

> **Windows SmartScreen**
> If Windows says "Windows protected your PC", click **More info** → **Run anyway**. This appears for new programs that aren't code-signed yet.

On first start, Homebox creates your AI folder `C:\Users\<you>\Homebox Workspace` with a `WELCOME.txt` inside, and its settings folder `C:\Users\<you>\.homebox`.

2.3 The setup guide (3 steps)

The first time you open the app, a setup guide appears. You can open it again any time: **Home** → **Setup guide** or **Help** → **Open the setup guide**.

Step	What you do
1. Your AI folder	See which folder the AI will work in. Keep the default or choose another one with **Choose folder…**. Use a project folder, never your whole user folder.
2. Add Homebox to your browser	Download the extension, load it in your browser and connect it (details below). The step turns green when your browser is connected. You can also approve the pairing code right here.
3. Give the AI its first task	Open an AI chat site in a new chat, click the round Homebox button, type a task and click **Start task**.

2.4 Installing the browser extension

1. In the app, go to **Connect AI** and click **Download extension**. Right-click the downloaded zip and choose **Extract All**. (The installer also ships a ready `homebox-extension` folder.)

2. In your browser's address bar type `chrome://extensions` (Edge: `edge://extensions`) and press Enter.
3. Turn on **Developer mode** (top right).
4. Click **Load unpacked** and choose the unzipped **homebox-extension** folder.
5. Click the puzzle-piece icon in the toolbar and pin **Homebox**.

2.5 Connecting (pairing) a browser

1. Click the Homebox icon in the browser toolbar, then **Connect to Homebox**.
2. The browser shows a short code. The Homebox app shows a request with a code.
3. If the codes match, click **Approve** in the app. If they don't match, click **No**.

You only do this once per browser. The browser gets a private key that only works with your Homebox. You can see and remove connected browsers on **Connect AI** → **Connected browsers**. At most 3 pairing requests can wait at the same time, so a web page can't flood you with them.

PART 3

The Homebox app, page by page

3.1 Sidebar, top bar, Full access and Pause

The **sidebar** on the left lists the pages. Badges show how many approvals are waiting and if a browser wants to pair. At the bottom are two important controls:

Full access switch	When on, the AI runs everything you turned on **without asking you first**. An orange banner at the top reminds you it's on, with a **Turn off** button. Things set to Off stay off. Default: off.
Pause button ("AI access on")	The emergency stop. One click instantly blocks every AI action, from every browser, MCP app and paste. Click again to allow access. Also in the tray menu and with `Ctrl` + `Shift` + `P`.

The **top bar** shows where you are, a **Search or jump to...** box (`Ctrl` + `K`), a **Show me around** button (a guided tour) and a light/dark theme button.

3.2 Home

- **How Homebox works**: the three steps (pick a folder, ask on an AI site, approve), with a **Setup guide** button.
- **Get started**: a checklist that ticks itself off as you set things up (folder chosen, browser connected, first task, and so on), with a progress label.
- **Today**: the latest things the AI did, with **See all** leading to Activity.
- Status cards for the AI folder, connected browsers and apps.

3.3 Approvals

Every action that needs your OK waits here (and also appears in the browser panel). Each card shows:

- **What** the AI wants to do, in plain words, for example "*Write index.html (2.1 KB)*" or "*Blender: run 12 lines of Python*".
- **Where it came from**: which site or app and which browser.
- **The full content**: the file text, the change, or the code, with colouring. Up to 100,000 characters are shown. If something is longer, a warning tells you how much is hidden; code over 100,000 characters is refused so you never approve something you can't read.
- **Approve** and **Deny**. `Enter` approves and `Esc` denies the top request.

If you deny, the AI is told "The user denied this action. Do not retry it; ask the user what they want instead."

3.4 Activity and Undo

A log of everything the AI did or tried, newest first: successful steps, errors, denied steps and steps blocked because something was off or paused. You can filter by text. File changes have an **Undo** button (Part 9

explains exactly what Undo does). The log is also saved to `.homebox\audit.jsonl`.

3.5 AI folder (and adding pictures)

- **Active folder**: the folder the AI works in now. Buttons open it in File Explorer.
- **Add pictures or files**: drag pictures or files onto the box, or click **Choose files...**. Pictures are saved into a `pictures` folder and other files into a `files` folder inside your AI folder, so the AI can use them. Up to 20 MB per file. Names are cleaned and nothing is ever overwritten (a number is added instead).
- **Use a different folder**: add another folder (tick **Create if missing** to make a new one) or pick one with the folder picker, then make it active. You can switch between several project folders.

> **Never pick your whole user folder or a drive**
> The AI folder is the fence. Pick a project folder that only contains what the AI should see.

3.6 Connect AI

Three tabs (the last two show when **Show advanced options** is on):

- **Browser extension**: install steps, the download, connected browsers (with Remove), and the list of supported AI sites with how to start.
- **MCP apps**: your private MCP link for apps like Claude Desktop, Cursor or VS Code's AI (Part 6).
- **Paste a reply**: works with any chatbot, no extension (Part 6).

3.7 Apps

A grid of all supported programs, grouped by category (3D & VFX, Adobe, Office, CAD, Streaming, Code), with a search box. Each tile shows whether the app is on and connected. Clicking a tile opens a side panel with:

- **Let AI control <app>**: the on/off switch. Every step still asks you first unless Full access is on.
- **Test connection**: checks the app is reachable and shows its version.
- **Start automatically** (where possible): makes the bridge start every time the app opens.
- **Set up step by step**: a numbered guide with lines to copy, how you know it worked, and fixes for common problems.

3.8 Maya

Shown in the menu when advanced options are on (Maya is also on the Apps page). It has the status, a **Test connection** button, **Let AI control Maya**, **Start with Maya automatically** (adds a clearly marked block to `Documents\maya\scripts\userSetup.py`), and the step-by-step setup guide.

3.9 Settings

Setting	What it does	Default

Full access	Approves every action you turned on automatically. Off items stay off; Pause still stops everything.	Off
Read files	Let the AI look at files and folders in the AI folder. Automatic / Ask me / Off.	Automatic
Change files	Create, edit, move and delete files in the AI folder. Every change can be undone. Automatic / Ask me / Off.	Ask me
Run commands advanced	Run command-line programs in the AI folder. Commands can reach outside the folder, so this is only Ask me or Off.	Off
Control browser tabs	Lets the AI read tabs, fill forms, open email drafts and play games on sites you allow. Ask me or Off. Typing, clicking and emails always ask, even with Full access.	Off
Control Maya / apps	Each app has its own permission, Ask me or Off (set on the Apps page).	Off
Round limit advanced	When the AI works by itself, Homebox stops after this many rounds, so it can't run forever.	30
Show advanced options	Shows the Maya page, MCP links, paste mode, running commands and the round limit. Off keeps Homebox simple.	Off
Theme	System, Light or Dark.	System
Reduce motion	Turns off animations.	Off
Notifications	Windows alerts when an approval is waiting and the window is in the background.	On
Quit Homebox	Stops the app. The AI loses all access until you start it again.	–

Under each permission, a short line explains in plain words what the chosen option means, for example *"Each change waits for you to click Approve. (Recommended)*".

3.10 Help, tour and search

- **Help** page: searchable answers, **Open the setup guide**, **What does each part do?** (every page explained), and the keyboard shortcuts.
- **Show me around** (map icon in the top bar): a guided tour that highlights each part.
- **Search or jump to…** (`Ctrl` + `K`): type a page or command name and press Enter.
- Hover any control with a small tooltip to see what it does.

3.11 Tray icon

Closing the window keeps Homebox running in the Windows tray (by the clock), so the AI can keep working. Right-click the tray icon for: **Open Homebox**, **Approvals**, **Pause all AI access / Resume AI access**, and **Quit Homebox**. Only one copy of Homebox runs at a time; opening it again shows the existing window.

3.12 Keyboard shortcuts

`Ctrl` + `K`	Search and commands
`Ctrl` + `1` … `8`	Go to page 1 to 8 (Home, Approvals, Activity, AI folder, Connect AI, Apps, Maya, Settings)
`F1`	Help
`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `L`	Switch theme
`Enter` / `Esc`	Approve / deny the top request (on Approvals)
`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `P`	Pause / resume AI
`/`	Focus the search on the current page
`Alt` + `Shift` + `H` (in the browser)	Show or hide the Homebox panel on an AI site

PART 4

The browser extension

4.1 The round Homebox button

On a supported AI site, a round **Homebox** button sits at the bottom right. A small pill next to it shows the state: **Needs your OK** (an approval is waiting) or **AI is working…**. Click the button (or `Alt`+`Shift`+`H`) to open the panel. The panel lives in a closed, private part of the page, so the AI site's own scripts can't read or click it, and it ignores fake (scripted) clicks.

4.2 The panel: type, add pictures, start

The top of the panel shows the AI folder name. If the app isn't running or the browser isn't connected, the panel says so and gives one button to fix it. Otherwise it shows three simple steps:

1. **Tell the AI what to do**: type your task in the big box. Type here, **not** in the chat's own message box, because Homebox adds the instructions the AI needs. Example: *"Make a simple website for my bakery with a home page and a menu page."* Below it, **Ideas** chips fill in example tasks with one click.
2. **Add pictures or files** (optional): drag them onto the box, click **Choose files…**, or paste a picture into the task box. They're always saved into your AI folder (`pictures` / `files`). The tick box **Also show the pictures to the AI** (on by default) also attaches pictures to the chat so the AI can see them.
3. **Start**: click **Start task** (or press `Ctrl`+`Enter`). Homebox puts the starter prompt plus your task into the chat and sends it.

> **Always start in a new chat**
> The AI only learns which functions and apps it may use at the start of a chat. After you turn on a new app, open a new chat.

4.3 Working by itself (auto-run)

The switch **Let the AI keep working by itself** is **on by default**. When on, Homebox runs each step the AI writes and sends the results back automatically, round after round, until the AI says **DONE** or the round limit (default 30) is reached. Anything that changes your files or apps still waits for your approval, unless Full access is on. Turn it off if you'd rather click **Run** on each step yourself.

4.4 Steps, results and Stop

- **Steps the AI wrote**: each detected step with its state (waiting, running, done, error) and a **Run** button when auto-run is off.
- **Approvals**: waiting approvals also appear in the panel with **Approve** and **Deny**.
- **What Homebox sent back to the AI**: the last results, with **Copy** and **Put in chat box** (use this if the AI didn't receive them).
- **Stop the AI**: stops the steps and turns off working by itself.
- **Open Homebox app**: jumps to the app.

When the chat gets very long, the panel suggests starting a new chat, because long chats make AI sites slow.

4.5 The toolbar popup

Click the Homebox icon in the browser toolbar to:

- Connect this browser (pairing) and see if the app is running.
- See which permissions are on, in plain words.
- Read **How to start a task**.
- **Enable** Homebox on another website that isn't in the list below. The browser asks your permission for that site. Only the popup can do this, never a web page.

4.6 Supported AI sites

Built in: ChatGPT (chatgpt.com), Claude (claude.ai), Gemini and Google AI Studio, LMArena, DeepSeek, Grok (grok.com and x.com), Qwen, Mistral Le Chat, Kimi, Perplexity, Microsoft Copilot, Poe, HuggingChat and Z.ai. Others can be enabled from the popup.

> **Check each site's terms**
> Some AI services don't allow their websites to be used through automated tools. Only use Homebox on sites whose terms allow it (see Part 13).

4.7 Crash protection on fast sites

Very fast back-and-forth can make chat pages freeze ("Page unresponsive"). Homebox prevents this:

- At least **3 seconds** between automatic sends, and at most **8 automatic sends per minute**.
- Results sent back to the chat are capped at 16,000 characters; the AI is told to read smaller parts if it needs more.
- The page is watched efficiently (only changed parts are checked), not rescanned from scratch.
- The round limit stops runaway loops.

4.8 Browser tabs, CVs, job applications, emails and games

The AI can also work in your other browser tabs. This is off until you turn it on.

Turning it on

1. In the Homebox app, go to **Settings** and set **Control browser tabs** to **Ask me**.
2. Open the website you want help with (for example a job site or a game).
3. Click the Homebox icon in the browser toolbar and click **Let AI control this site**. The browser asks you to allow it. Only sites you allow this way can be read or used, and you can stop any time with **Stop letting AI use this site**.
4. Start a new chat and give the task from the Homebox panel.

What the AI can do

Read your CV	Drag your CV (PDF or Word) into the panel or the AI folder. The AI reads it with `read_document`. Scanned CVs have no text: attach them as a picture.
LinkedIn profile	Use the idea **LinkedIn from my CV**. The AI writes your headline, About, jobs and skills and shows them in the panel with a **Copy** button for each. You paste them into LinkedIn yourself. Homebox never controls LinkedIn, because LinkedIn's User Agreement doesn't allow automation tools.
Job applications	On job sites you allow (for example JobsDB or Offer Today), use **Help me apply for a job**. The AI reads the form, fills what it can from your CV and writes a cover letter. You check everything and press **Submit** yourself. Check each job site's terms first; many don't allow mass automated applications.
Emails	The AI opens a Gmail (or Outlook) draft with the address, subject and text filled in. You read it and press **Send**. For attachments, the AI tells you which file to attach.
Tabs	List, open, switch to and close tabs, and read the pages of allowed sites.
Games	Single-player, turn-based games (chess against the computer, Wordle, Sudoku, puzzles). The AI takes a picture of the tab, picks one move, clicks or presses keys, and looks again. Put the game in its own browser window next to the chat. Fast action games don't work, and online games against people would count as cheating.

Safety rules that always apply

- Every typing, click, key press and email waits for your **Approve**, **even with Full access on**. The approval shows the real field names and the exact text.
- Homebox never types into password, card, bank or one-time-code fields, and never uploads files.
- Homebox never presses final buttons: Send, Submit, Apply, Pay, Buy, Post, Share, Save, Confirm, Delete, Sign in or Sign up. You do.
- Enter is never pressed inside forms or message boxes, and Ctrl/Alt shortcuts aren't allowed.
- Never controlled: LinkedIn, AI chat sites, sign-in pages, the extension store and Homebox itself.
- Text on web pages is passed to the AI marked as data, and the AI is told never to follow instructions found on a page.

4.9 Ask AI from any tab

You don't have to open an AI site first. Type your task in any of these places:

- The **Ask AI** box at the top of the toolbar popup (press `Ctrl`+`Enter` to send).
- The address bar: type **hb**, a space, then your task, and press Enter.
- `Alt`+`Shift`+`H` on any normal page opens the Ask AI box. On an AI site it still shows the panel.

Which AI it picks

Kind of task	Example	First choice

Computer tasks (code, files, apps, tabs)	"Make me a website for my bakery"	Claude
Hard thinking	"Plan a 7-day trip to Japan"	ChatGPT
Research and latest news	"Latest phone prices today"	Perplexity
Writing	"Write a cover letter for this job"	Claude
Quick question	"What's the capital of France?"	ChatGPT

These are starting points, not a ranking. Change the first choice for each kind under **Which AI for which task** in the popup, and tick AIs you never want to use. Writing "use Claude" (or any AI's name) in your task picks that AI. Tasks that need your computer are sent with Homebox's instructions; plain questions are sent as they are. You can change this with **Use my computer**.

Logging in, outages and switching

- **Not logged in:** the panel says "Log in to Claude. Homebox will type your task as soon as you're in." It waits up to 20 minutes.
- **AI unavailable:** if the site is down, at capacity, out of messages or never shows a chat box, the task moves to the next AI on the list by itself. If an AI runs out of messages right after the task is sent, the task moves too, but only if nothing has run on your computer yet, so no step runs twice.
- **Want another AI:** choose it under **Use another AI** in the panel. Before sending, the task moves in the same tab. After sending, it opens in a new tab so you keep the first chat.
- Reloading the page never sends the task twice.

Pictures of tabs: Chrome lets Homebox take a full picture of a tab after you click the Homebox toolbar button on that tab (for example when you clicked **Let AI control this site**). For games drawn on a canvas, Homebox can picture the game area by itself.

PART 5

Connecting your apps

5.1 How app connections work

Each app is **off** until you turn it on. When it's on, the AI gets one function for that app (for example `blender_run_python`) and the starter prompt explains how to use it. Every step waits for your approval unless Full access is on. Homebox talks to apps in four ways:

Way	Used by	How it works
Python bridge	Maya, Blender, Houdini, 3ds Max, Cinema 4D, Nuke, Unreal, Substance 3D Painter	You run one setup line in the app (or turn on Start automatically). It starts a small listener on your PC that only accepts Homebox, using a secret key stored in your `.homebox` folder. Each step runs inside the app and is one undo step there.
Windows automation (COM)	Photoshop, Illustrator, Excel, Word, PowerPoint, AutoCAD	Homebox uses the app's official Windows scripting interface. Nothing to install in the app; just have it open.
After Effects scripting	After Effects	Runs ExtendScript through After Effects' own command-line option.
WebSocket	OBS Studio	Uses OBS's built-in obs-websocket server.

5.2 All 18 apps at a glance

App	AI function	Language	Port	What the AI can do	Undo
Maya	`maya_run_python`, `maya_scene_info`	Python	7017	Model, rig, animate, read the scene	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
Blender	`blender_run_python`	Python (bpy)	7010	Model, light, animate and render	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
Houdini	`houdini_run_python`	Python (hou)	7011	Node networks, SOPs, simulations	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
3ds Max	`max_run_python`	Python (pymxs)	7012	Create and edit scenes	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
Cinema 4D	`c4d_run_python`	Python (c4d)	7013	Scenes and motion graphics	When the AI adds undo marks
Nuke	`nuke_run_python`	Python	7014	Compositing node trees	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
Unreal Engine	`unreal_run_python`	Python	7015	Place actors, edit levels and assets	1 step = 1 transaction

Substance 3D Painter	`painter_run_python`	Python	7016	Projects, texture sets, layers, exports	Limited
Photoshop	`photoshop_run_jsx`	ExtendScript	–	Documents, layers, text, exports	1 step = 1 History step
Illustrator	`illustrator_run_jsx`	ExtendScript	–	Shapes, text, artboards	Ctrl+Z in the app
After Effects	`aftereffects_run_jsx`	ExtendScript	–	Compositions, layers, keyframes, render queue	1 step = 1 undo group
Excel	`excel_run_powershell`	PowerShell	–	Fill sheets, formulas, charts	**No**: save first
Word	`word_run_powershell`	PowerShell	–	Write and format documents	1 step = 1 Ctrl+Z
PowerPoint	`powerpoint_run_powershell`	PowerShell	–	Slides, text, layouts	**No**: save first
AutoCAD	`autocad_run_powershell`	PowerShell	–	Draw and edit the open drawing	1 step = 1 undo mark
OBS Studio	`obs_request`	WebSocket	4455	Scenes, sources, recording, streaming	–
VS Code	`vscode_info`, `vscode_problems`, `vscode_open`	any	7018–7027	Edit, add and delete code with file functions	Homebox Undo
GitHub	`github_info`, `github_publish`	git + GitHub CLI	–	Publish project folders as repositories	–

5.3 3D and VFX apps (Python bridge)

The setup is the same idea for each one. Exact steps, with the line to copy, are in each app's panel on the Apps page.

1. On the Apps page, open the app and turn on **Let AI control <app>**.
2. Open the app's Python console:
   - **Maya**: Windows → General Editors → Script Editor → Python tab.
   - **Blender**: the Scripting tab → Python Console.
   - **Houdini**: Windows → Python Shell.
   - **3ds Max**: Scripting → MAXScript Listener, Python mode.
   - **Cinema 4D**: install the `homebox_c4d.pyp` plugin (shown in the guide).
   - **Nuke**: the Script Editor.
   - **Unreal**: the Output Log, Python mode (the Python plugin must be enabled).
   - **Painter**: its Python console.

3. Paste the setup line and run it. The app prints `Homebox: <app> is listening on port <port>`.
4. Click **Test connection**. It turns green and shows the app's version.
5. Optional: turn on **Start automatically**, so you never paste the line again. Homebox adds a clearly marked block to that app's startup script (for example Maya's `userSetup.py` or Houdini's `456.py`) and never touches your own lines.
6. Start a **new chat** and ask, for example: *"In Blender, model a low-poly campfire with stones around it."*

Maya extras: `maya_scene_info` lists every object with its type, parent, centre, size and the selection. It's a fixed, read-only script written by Homebox, so it doesn't need approval. The AI can't see the viewport, so it works with numbers and asks you how it looks.

> **Upgrading from Homebox 1.x**
> Homebox 2.0 replaced Maya's old command port 7001 (which would run code from anyone, even a web page) with the secure bridge on port 7017, and updated your `userSetup.py` automatically. Remove any `commandPort(':7001')` lines you added yourself.

5.4 Adobe apps

- **Photoshop and Illustrator**: just have the app open. Homebox sends ExtendScript (old-style JavaScript) through Windows automation.
- **After Effects**: have it open. Homebox runs scripts through After Effects' own scripting option, and each step is one undo group. You may need to allow scripts in **Edit → Preferences → Scripting & Expressions**.

5.5 Office and AutoCAD

Have the program open with your document. Homebox runs a short PowerShell script that talks to the open app (variables like `$excel`, `$word`, `$ppt`, `$acad` are ready for the AI).

> **Excel and PowerPoint can't undo script changes**
> Save your file before asking the AI to change it. The AI is told to work carefully and warn you before big edits.

5.6 OBS Studio

1. In OBS: **Tools → WebSocket Server Settings**, tick **Enable WebSocket server**. Note the port (4455) and the password.
2. In Homebox, open OBS on the Apps page, enter the port and password, and click **Test connection**.
3. The AI uses `obs_request` with an obs-websocket request name, for example `SetCurrentProgramScene` or `StartRecord`.

5.7 VS Code

With VS Code, the AI edits, adds and deletes code using the normal Homebox file functions (so everything is approved and undoable), and the Homebox VS Code extension lets it see your editor.

1. On the Apps page, open VS Code and turn it on. One switch installs the Homebox extension into VS Code (desktop app) through the `code` command.
2. Restart VS Code (or reload the window). A **Homebox** item appears in the status bar.
3. Open your project folder in VS Code.

Several windows and folders: each VS Code window with Homebox gets its own port (7018 to 7027). Click **Homebox** in a window's status bar to make that window's folder your AI folder. You can switch between projects any time.

It works with the desktop VS Code app (not vscode.dev in the browser), because the browser version can't reach programs on your PC. The extension updates itself when Homebox has a newer version.

5.8 GitHub

The AI builds projects in their own folders inside your AI folder (for example `projects/maya-batch-renamer`), then publishes each one to your GitHub with a README, a licence and a .gitignore.

Setup (once)

1. Apps → **GitHub** → turn on **Let AI control GitHub**.
2. Install Git: `winget install --id Git.Git -e` (skip if you have it).
3. Install the GitHub CLI: `winget install --id GitHub.cli -e`.
4. Sign in: `gh auth login`, choose GitHub.com, HTTPS and "Login with a web browser". You sign in on GitHub's own page; Homebox never sees your password.
5. Click **Test connection**. It says **signed in as** your GitHub name.

Using it

In a new chat, click the idea **Build my GitHub**. The AI reads your CV, checks your existing repositories, proposes about 5 projects that fit your skills, builds the first one and asks to publish it.

Safety

- Every upload asks you, even with Full access, and the approval lists every file that will go online.
- New repositories are private unless you or the AI ask for public, and the approval says **PUBLIC** in capitals when it is.
- Commits use your GitHub "noreply" email address, so your real email never appears publicly.
- Refused: publishing the whole AI folder, any project containing keys, passwords or `.env` files, and documents that look like a CV.
- Homebox runs git and the GitHub CLI itself with fixed commands. The AI never gets a command line.
- The AI is told to build a few real, working projects and never to fake activity (no backdated commits or filler commits). Recruiters notice, and GitHub's rules forbid it.

PART 6

Other ways to connect an AI

Turn on **Settings** → **Show advanced options** to see these on the Connect AI page.

6.1 MCP apps

MCP (Model Context Protocol) is an open standard that AI apps such as Claude Desktop, Cursor and VS Code's AI features use to add tools. It's an officially supported way to connect an AI to Homebox.

1. Go to **Connect AI** → **MCP apps** and copy your private link. It looks like `http://127.0.0.1:7777/mcp/<secret>`.
2. Add it as an MCP server in your AI app's settings.
3. The AI app now sees Homebox's functions directly. Approvals, Full access, Pause and Undo work the same.

The link works only on this computer. Keep it secret, and click **Make a new link** if it leaks. Web pages can't use it, because Homebox checks where requests come from.

6.2 Paste mode

Works with any chatbot, with no extension:

1. Copy the starter prompt from **Connect AI** → **Paste a reply** into the chat, followed by your task.
2. Copy the AI's whole reply and paste it into Homebox. Click **Run**.
3. Homebox runs the steps (asking where needed) and shows the results. Copy them back into the chat.
4. Repeat until the AI says **DONE**.

PART 7

Permissions and safety

7.1 Automatic, Ask me, Off

Mode	Meaning	Available for
Automatic	Runs without asking. Still logged; file changes can still be undone.	Read files, Change files only
Ask me	Waits on the Approvals page and in the browser panel until you approve.	Everything
Off	The AI isn't even told this function exists. If it tries anyway, it's blocked and logged.	Everything

Running commands and controlling apps can reach outside the AI folder, so they can never be Automatic. They're always Ask me or Off (unless you turn on Full access).

7.2 Full access

Full access skips the question for everything that is **not Off**. It's for tasks you trust when you don't want to click Approve every time. It doesn't turn anything on that's off, and Pause still stops everything instantly. A banner shows while it's on.

> **Use Full access carefully**
> With Full access and commands or apps turned on, the AI can run code on your PC without asking. Only use it with an AI and a task you trust, and keep backups.

7.3 The AI folder (sandbox)

All file functions only work inside the active AI folder. Homebox checks every path before using it:

- Paths that leave the folder (`..\` , other drives, absolute paths) are refused.
- Shortcuts and links (symlinks, junctions) that point outside are refused, because Homebox resolves the real location first.
- Windows tricks are refused: hidden data streams (`file.txt:secret`), names ending with dots or spaces, and reserved names like `CON` or `NUL` .
- The AI can't delete the whole AI folder itself.

7.4 Hidden secret files

Even inside the AI folder, these are invisible to the AI and can't be read or changed: `.env` files, `.ssh` , `.aws` , `.azure` , `.kube` , `.gnupg` , gcloud settings, keys and certificates (`.pem` , `.key` , `.p12` , `.pfx` , `.ppk` , `.kdbx` , `id_rsa` ...), `.npmrc` , `.netrc` , `.pypirc` , `.pgpass` , `.git-credentials` , `.git/config` , Docker config,

`credentials` and `client_secret*.json`, and Homebox's own `.homebox` folder. Folders that contain such files can't be deleted by the AI.

7.5 How Homebox protects itself

- **Only your PC**: the server listens on `127.0.0.1`, which other computers can't reach. Requests must also name a local address, which blocks "DNS rebinding" tricks.
- **Separate keys for each door**:
  - The control panel needs a special header that web pages can't send.
  - Browsers need their pairing key.
  - MCP needs its secret link.
  - App bridges need their own secret key.
- **Web pages can't misuse it**:
  - Pairing needs your approval in the app.
  - MCP refuses web-page origins.
  - The panel can't be shown inside another site (anti-clickjacking).
  - Enabling new sites only works from the popup.
- **Hardened desktop app**: Electron security switches ("fuses") are set, so the installed app can't be abused to run arbitrary scripts.
- **Everything logged**: every action, allowed or not, goes into the activity log.
- **Self-check**: before every installer build, 27 automatic checks test these protections (sandbox escapes, the doors, deletes and undo).

PART 8

Every function the AI can use

"Functions" (also called tools) are the actions the AI may ask Homebox to do. The AI only sees functions whose permission isn't Off.

8.1 File functions

Function	Permission	What it does
`workspace_info`	Read files	Shows the AI folder name, operating system, permissions and which apps are connected.
`list_dir`	Read files	Lists files and folders (`.` = the AI folder itself).
`read_file`	Read files	Reads a text file (up to 200,000 bytes; longer files are cut and say so).
`search`	Read files	Finds lines containing some text (not case-sensitive) in files under a folder. Skips heavy folders like `node_modules` , `.git` , `dist` .
`write_file`	Change files	Creates or overwrites a text file (and its parent folders). The old version is saved for Undo.
`edit_file`	Change files	Replaces an exact piece of text in a file. The text must appear exactly once, unless "replace all" is set. Undoable.
`make_dir`	Change files	Creates a folder (and its parents). Undoable.
`move_path`	Change files	Moves or renames a file or folder inside the AI folder. The destination must not exist. Undoable.
`delete_path`	Change files	Deletes a file or folder after making a full backup, so Undo can bring it back. Refuses links, protected files, the AI folder itself, and anything over 20,000 files or 500 MB.
`read_document`	Read files	Reads the text of a PDF or Word (.docx) file, such as a CV (up to 30 MB, 200 pages).
`show_copy_text`	Read files	Shows finished text in the browser panel with a Copy button per part (LinkedIn sections, application answers). No approval needed: it only shows text.

8.2 Command function

`run_command`	Run commands	Runs a command-line command in the AI folder (cmd.exe on Windows). Every command asks you (unless Full access). Default timeout 120 s, max 600 s. Output up to 60,000 characters plus the exit code.

8.3 Maya functions

`maya_run_python`	Control Maya	Runs Python in your open Maya (`cmds` ready, `SANDBOX` = the AI folder path). `print()` output comes back. One undo step per run. Timeout default 120 s, max 600 s.
`maya_scene_info`	Control Maya	Lists every object with its type, parent, centre and size, plus the selection. No approval needed (fixed read-only script).

Browser and email functions

Permission: **Control browser tabs**. These only work for tasks started from the browser panel, and only on sites you allowed.

`browser_tabs`	Lists open tabs with numbers. Tabs on sites you didn't allow only show the site name.
`browser_read`	Reads a tab's text and gives a numbered list of its buttons, links and fields, marking protected fields and final buttons.
`browser_screenshot`	Takes a picture of a tab and attaches it to the chat.
`browser_open`	Opens a web address in a new tab. Always asks.
`browser_switch` / `browser_close`	Brings a tab to the front / closes a tab (only tabs Homebox opened or on allowed sites). Closing always asks.
`browser_fill`	Fills form fields by number (text, dropdowns, tick boxes). Always asks, showing each field name and text.
`browser_click`	Clicks an element by number, or a point on the last picture. Always asks. Refuses final buttons.
`browser_keys`	Types letters and presses named keys (arrows, Space, Enter…), for games. Always asks.
`github_info`	Checks the GitHub setup and lists your repositories. Needs no approval (it only reads).
`github_publish`	Publishes one project folder: creates the repository the first time, then commits and pushes. Always asks, showing every file.
`email_compose`	Opens a Gmail or Outlook draft with to, cc, subject and text. Always asks. You press Send.

8.4 App functions

One per app, named `<app>_run_<language>`: `blender_run_python`, `houdini_run_python`, `max_run_python`, `c4d_run_python`, `nuke_run_python`, `unreal_run_python`, `painter_run_python`, `photoshop_run_jsx`, `illustrator_run_jsx`, `aftereffects_run_jsx`, `excel_run_powershell`, `word_run_powershell`, `powerpoint_run_powershell`, `autocad_run_powershell`, plus `obs_request` (request name and data). Each one runs code in the open app and returns its output. The starter prompt gives the AI a short example and tips per app.

8.5 VS Code functions

`vscode_info`	What you're doing in VS Code: active file, cursor line and selected text, open files, which files have **unsaved** changes, and the number of errors and warnings. Only files inside the AI folder are reported.
`vscode_problems`	The errors and warnings from VS Code's Problems panel (for the whole folder or one file). The AI uses this to check its work after editing.
`vscode_open`	Opens a file in VS Code at a line, so you can see what was changed.

8.6 The homebox block format

The AI writes steps as fenced code blocks marked `homebox`. The full form is JSON:

````
```homebox
{"tool": "list_dir", "args": {"path": "."}}
```
````

Several actions can go in one block as a list: `[{"tool": …, "args": …}, {…}]`. There are also short forms that are easier for the AI:

````
```homebox
write_file notes/todo.md
# My list
- first item
```

```homebox
blender_run_python
import bpy
bpy.ops.mesh.primitive_cube_add(size=2)
```
````

Other short forms:

- `read_file <path>`
- `list_dir <path>`
- `make_dir <path>`
- `delete_path <path>`
- `search <text>`
- `run_command <command>`
- `workspace_info`
- `maya_scene_info`
- `vscode_info`
- `vscode_problems [path]`
- `vscode_open <path>:<line>`

- `obs_request <Request>` followed by JSON data

Results come back to the AI starting with `[Homebox results]`, one section per action marked OK or ERROR. Triple backticks inside file contents are shown as `'''` so they don't break the chat's formatting.

8.7 Limits

Reading a file	200,000 bytes
Command output	60,000 characters
Results sent back to the chat	16,000 characters
Code length the AI may submit for approval	100,000 characters
Approval preview	100,000 characters (with a warning if more)
Uploaded picture or file	20 MB each
Delete with backup	20,000 files / 500 MB
Command / app step timeout	120 s default, 600 s max
Automatic rounds	30 by default (Settings → Round limit)
Automatic sends	3 s apart, max 8 per minute
Actions per AI message (guideline)	about 5

PART 9

Undo in detail

Before every file change, Homebox saves what's needed to put it back, in `C:\Users\<you>\.homebox\snapshots`. On the **Activity** page, click **Undo** next to the change.

The AI did…	Undo does…
Overwrote or edited a file	Puts the saved earlier version back.
Created a new file	Removes the file.
Created a folder	Removes the folder (if it's empty).
Moved or renamed something	Moves it back (if nothing has taken its old place).
Deleted a file or folder	Restores the full backup (if nothing new is at that path).

- Each change can be undone once. Undo itself is logged.
- Undo covers **file changes**. Commands and app steps aren't covered by Homebox's Undo. Most 3D apps let you press `Ctrl`+`Z` once per AI step; Excel and PowerPoint can't undo script changes at all.
- If you changed the file yourself after the AI did, Undo still restores the AI's "before" version, so check first.

PART 10

Under the hood

10.1 Files Homebox keeps on your PC

`C:\Users\<you>\.homebox\config.json`	All settings: folders, permissions, Full access, paired browsers, MCP secret, app settings. Only your Windows user can read it.
`.homebox\snapshots\`	Undo copies and delete backups.
`.homebox\audit.jsonl`	The activity log, one line per action.
`.homebox\` bridge key file	The secret the app bridges use.
`C:\Users\<you>\Homebox Workspace\`	The default AI folder.
App startup scripts	Only when you turn on Start automatically: a clearly marked Homebox block, for example in Maya's `userSetup.py`.

Homebox 2.0 uses the same `.homebox` folder as 1.x, so pairings survive the upgrade. Nothing is sent to any server of ours: there are no accounts, no cloud and no tracking in the app.

10.2 Ports

Port	Used for
7777 (next free up to 7787)	The Homebox app: control panel, extension, MCP, live updates
7010–7017	Python bridges: Blender 7010, Houdini 7011, 3ds Max 7012, Cinema 4D 7013, Nuke 7014, Unreal 7015, Painter 7016, Maya 7017
7018–7027	VS Code windows (one port per window)
4455	OBS WebSocket (OBS's own setting)

All of these only listen on `127.0.0.1` (this PC).

10.3 Source code map

The project folder is `Homebox-1.0.0-Windows`. Inside it:

File	Job
`homebox-app/src/main.js`	The desktop app (Electron): window, tray, single instance, notifications.
`src/core/server.js`	The local server: panel API, extension API, MCP, uploads, live events, security headers.
`src/core/tools.js`	The function list, permissions, approvals, Undo, starter prompt, reading homebox blocks, formatting results.

`src/core/files.js`	File functions, run_command, uploads, delete safety, limits.
`src/core/sandbox.js`	The AI-folder fence and the hidden-secrets list.
`src/core/hub.js`	Approval queue, activity log, pause.
`src/core/config.js`	Settings loading and saving, defaults.
`src/core/apps.js`	The app list and how each app is reached; auto-start; tests.
`src/core/bridge.js`, `maya.js`	Talking to the Python bridges; Maya specifics.
`src/core/vscode.js`	VS Code functions, installing and updating the VS Code extension.
`src/core/zip.js`	Builds the extension zip and VS Code package.
`src/ui/index.html`, `app.js`, `app.css`, `guides.js`	The control panel, setup guide, app guides.
`bridges/homebox_bridge.py`	The Python bridge used by all 3D/VFX apps; `bridges/c4d/homebox_c4d.pyp` for Cinema 4D.
`extension/`	The browser extension: `content.js` (panel on chat sites), `background.js` (pairing, talking to the app), `popup.*`, `manifest.json`.
`vscode/`	The VS Code extension.
`scripts/check.js`	The 27 automatic safety checks.
`LICENSE.txt`	The licence agreement shown in the installer.
`Start Homebox.cmd`	Starts Homebox from source (for development).
`website/`	The public website (Part 11).

10.4 Building the installer

```
cd homebox-app
npm install
npm run check    # 27 safety checks
npm run dist     # runs the checks, then builds dist\Homebox-Setup-2.0.0.exe
```

The installer is an NSIS installer: it shows the licence page and lets the user choose the folder, then creates desktop and Start-menu shortcuts. The open-source notices (`LICENSE.electron.txt`, `LICENSES.chromium.html`) are included in the install folder. When you change the extension, copy it to `Homebox-1.0.0-Windows/homebox-extension` as well.

PART 11

The website

11.1 How the site is built

The site is plain HTML generated by a small script, so it's fast and can be hosted anywhere (Netlify, Cloudflare Pages, GitHub Pages, any web host).

- `website/site.config.json` : your details:
  - site name, company, author, version
  - `siteUrl` , `contactEmail` , `downloadUrl`
  - `adsenseClient` , `jurisdiction` , last updated date
- `website/pages/` : the page contents. Each starts with a title and description comment.
- `website/build.js` : builds every page into `website/public/` . It adds the menu, footer, breadcrumbs, related guides, structured data for Google, the sitemap, `robots.txt` and, when your AdSense id is set, the ad code and `ads.txt` .
- `website/check.js` : the pre-launch check (details below).

```
cd website
node build.js
node check.js
```

Upload the contents of `website/public` to your host.

11.2 Pages

- **Home**: what Homebox does, features, apps, screenshots.
- **Download**: the installer link and requirements.
- **Guides**: 16 in-depth guides (getting started, each app, VS Code, safety, choosing an AI site…).
- **FAQ**, **Glossary**, **Changelog**, **About** (with the author section), **Contact**.
- **Legal**: Privacy policy, Cookie policy, Terms of use, Disclaimer.
- A friendly **404** page.

11.3 Launch checklist and AdSense

`check.js` checks:

- your real details are filled in
- all required pages exist
- the privacy policy covers Google, cookies and opting out
- each guide has 600+ words
- titles and descriptions
- one main heading per page
- no placeholder text

- no broken links
- image alt text and sizes
- sitemap and robots

It prints **Ready to apply** when everything passes. Before publishing, fill in `siteUrl`, `contactEmail`, `downloadUrl` and `jurisdiction`. The full step-by-step AdSense plan is in `website/ADSENSE-LAUNCH.md`: get a domain, publish, add the site to Google Search Console, apply to AdSense, paste your `ca-pub-…` id into the config, rebuild and re-upload.

PART 12

Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
The panel says "The Homebox app isn't running"	Open Homebox (desktop shortcut or tray). Then click the button in the panel to retry.
No round Homebox button on the chat site	Reload the page. Check the extension is on at `chrome://extensions`. For an unlisted site, click **Enable** in the extension popup.
"Connect this browser to Homebox"	Click **Connect** and approve the matching code in the app.
The AI just talks and doesn't write steps	Start a **new chat** and use **Start task** in the panel (it sends the instructions). Some AI models follow instructions better than others; try another model.
The AI says it can't use an app	Turn the app on in Apps, then start a new chat.
"<App> is not listening / not connected"	Open the app and run the setup line again, or turn on Start automatically and restart the app. Click Test connection.
"did not answer in time"	A dialog is probably open in the app (Save, a warning). Close it and approve the step again.
"The user has turned off ..."	That permission is Off in Settings or Apps. Turn it on if you want it.
"Homebox is paused by the user"	Click the Pause button (sidebar) to allow AI access again.
Results didn't arrive in the chat	In the panel, click **Put in chat box** under "What Homebox sent back to the AI", then send.
Chat page is slow or "unresponsive"	Start a new chat; long chats are heavy. Homebox already spaces out sends.
Steps stop after a while	The round limit was reached. Raise it in Settings (advanced) or tell the AI to continue.
"is too long to review"	The AI's step was over 100,000 characters. Ask it to split the work into smaller steps.
"too big to back up for Undo"	The AI tried to delete something huge. Delete it yourself if you really want it gone.
VS Code shows no Homebox item	Turn VS Code on in Apps (installs the extension), then reload VS Code. Use the desktop app, not vscode.dev.
OBS doesn't connect	Enable the WebSocket server in OBS (Tools → WebSocket Server Settings) and enter the same port and password in Homebox.
Windows SmartScreen warning	Click **More info** → **Run anyway**.
Port 7777 is busy	Homebox uses the next free port up to 7787 automatically; the extension finds it.

PART 13

Legal and responsible use

This is a summary, not legal advice.

For people using Homebox

- **Licence agreement**: installing means accepting the licence in `LICENSE.txt` (shown in the installer). The full Terms of use are on the website.
- **Third-party terms**: you must follow the terms of every AI service and program you use with Homebox. Some AI services don't allow their websites to be used through automated tools. Check first, and don't use Homebox on sites whose terms don't allow it. MCP apps are an officially supported way to connect.
- **Your responsibility**: you choose what to allow and approve. Review code before it runs, keep backups, and use Full access only for trusted tasks.
- **AI can be wrong**: check anything important yourself.
- **Acceptable use**: no illegal use, no accessing systems you aren't allowed to, no malware, no getting around services' limits.
- **Minimum age**: 16 (or higher where local law requires).
- **Trademarks**: all app and AI names belong to their owners. Homebox isn't affiliated with or endorsed by any of them.

For the owner, before publishing

- Fill in `jurisdiction` (and your other details) in `site.config.json`.
- Do a trademark search on the name "Homebox". An open-source app with that name exists.
- Have a lawyer review the Terms of use and the licence agreement once.
- If Homebox grows, form a company to limit personal liability. If you ever sell it, use a reseller (merchant of record) that handles tax and VAT.
- If an AI company asks you to stop supporting its site, comply promptly.

PART 14

Glossary A to Z

Activity	The log of everything the AI did or tried, with Undo for file changes.
AdSense	Google's advertising program that pays the website owner for ads shown on the site.
AI folder	The only folder the AI may see and change. Also called the sandbox or workspace.
Approval	A step that waits for you to click Approve or Deny.
Auto-run	"Let the AI keep working by itself": Homebox runs steps and sends results back automatically.
Bridge	A small connector inside an app (for example Blender) that lets Homebox run steps there.
COM	Windows' built-in way for programs (Office, Photoshop, AutoCAD) to be controlled by scripts.
DONE	The word the AI writes when the whole task is finished.
CV / résumé	Your career document. The AI can read PDF and Word versions with read_document.
Electron	The framework the desktop app is built with.
EULA	End User Licence Agreement: the licence you accept in the installer.
ExtendScript	Adobe's scripting language (an old form of JavaScript).
Extension	The browser add-on that puts Homebox on AI chat sites.
Full access	Approves everything that's turned on, automatically.
Function / tool	An action the AI may ask Homebox to do, like write_file.
homebox block	A code block in the AI's reply marked `homebox` that holds a step.
Localhost / 127.0.0.1	The address that means "this computer". Other computers can't reach it.
MCP	Model Context Protocol: an open standard AI apps use to connect to tools like Homebox.
Pairing	Connecting a browser to Homebox once by confirming a matching code.
Paste mode	Using Homebox with any chatbot by copying replies and results by hand.
Pause	The emergency stop that blocks all AI access instantly.
Permission	Automatic, Ask me or Off, for each kind of action.
Port	A numbered "door" on your PC that a program listens on, like 7777.
PowerShell	Windows' scripting language, used to control Office and AutoCAD.
Round	One AI reply plus Homebox running its steps and sending results.
Round limit	The most rounds Homebox runs automatically before stopping (default 30).
Sandbox	See AI folder.

Snapshot	A saved copy used by Undo.
Starter prompt	The instructions Homebox sends to the AI with your first task.
Tray	The icons by the Windows clock; Homebox keeps running there.
Undo	Puts a file change back (Activity page).
WebSocket	A live connection type, used for OBS.
Workspace	See AI folder.